



Jews and Race Roundtable

Questions

Why is it useful to view Jews w/ a race?

Responses

All people have race + not thinking about race is a privilege - not observing typically indicative of dominant race. *[Seems to be in category by relevant - race + identity for modern Jews?]*
Jews sometimes viewed as a race or identity/identity themselves as a race
Race is important in modernity - Jews in convo of modernity (Nation-states, civilizations)
Even Medieval people racialized others even if it was not via modern pov - people experimented with the concept, modern concepts are more "hardened"
Race does not have stable definition - focus on the work that it does

Intra-Jewish

Intra-Jewish racial affiliation - 1400s. Switch from race as a metaphysical category to a bodily one
Lens of race helps understand how ppl understood themselves + contextual choices that they made. *[Seems to be a lot of the privilege + working within white as shows that modern America as Ashkenazim see themselves as white regardless of how others that see them]*
Where does unification of Jews break down historically? Typically by race.

Racialization in US

In the US - Jews typically contextualized as ~~+~~ - In 1800s, not all of ppl created the same hierarchy of classification (Jews, WASPs, slaves viewed as lesser white in 1800s)
Things difficult about being Jewish different from other white people
Malleability of if Jews are a religion or a race
Racism internal to Jewish community - experiencing oppression but also perpetuating it
If you want to understand American Jews, you have to grapple with racialization
Racialization is a political process and not a biological one

Jews are ultimately just trying to protect their own interests, which is why they define themselves w/ whiteness even though this ends up being harmful both within the Jewish community + outside of it.

Judaism across Americas in 1600s, 1700s, and 1800s	Jewish law w/ slavery + gender interrelationship between Jews and non-Jews Enslaved Africans w/ Jewish owners have Jewish experiences too ↳ Application of halacha to this Judaism matters to people enslaved by Jews Blessings for slaves so they are participating in Judaism involn family Do domestic slaves help w/ getting ready for a Jewish holiday
Racialization in middle ages	Identifying w/ whiteness is beneficial for Jews 1492 as watershed moment for racialization of Jews? People in Middle Ages had concept of race but not heritable Racialization → removal of racialization in future generations Slavery in middle ages was not racialized (theoretically) In some times and places, some groups used as slaves more frequently than others Theory of climates Jews often used this in Medieval Cairo to justify enslavement Slaves converting to Judaism → slave pasted over + future generations just viewed as Jews
Concept of race varying geographically	Discourses of race from one part of the world can influence racial discourse in other contexts elsewhere How did Mizrahi become a category of race? Reformulation of the black Jew of the 1400s and 1500s Condo + applied to Indian Jews, enslaved Jews, and Beta Israel Jews

prior to French colonialism - Arab Jews
Jews of Spain, Iraqi Jews, Sephardi
During + After French colonialism categories
is static as Jews vs Muslims vs Amazigh
Amazigh vs Sephardi Jews had
different experiences

Did racialization
depend on
Toshtani vs
Sephardi origin?
Side this is
often brought
up online

Concepts of race vary depending on context
In India, the Sephardi + Iraqi Jews were "white" but
nowhere else

North African Jews in 60s and 70s - those who move to
France become white, in Israel they do not
Jews in Algeria viewed as civilized by French but not neighboring
Jews

Why were Jews + Muslim N.Africans from the same
lands treated differently?

Jews of
color in the US
↳ How did
skin in language
take place?

JOC comes from term POC, arose in the 90s
Jews are minority in the US but have benefits of
whiteness - Amass wealth faster than other whites - **but isn't
this also true for some East Asians!**

JOC - can be born Jewish in racialized groups in communities that
were always Jewish but at given time + place viewed as race or ambiguous
↳ or trans/racial adopter - Jewish families relegated to intermarriage
adoption or "undesirable" domestic adoptee groups - significant
portion

60% of JOC have at least 1 Jewish parent who is typically
Ashkenazi*

Converts of color

Interfaith families

Interracial interfaith families where kids are biologically Jewish
↳ Religious discussions abt slavery - white Jewish adults need
to address robustly

Responses to feeling threatened entrenched in whiteness -

what this stat tells us is that predominantly white Jewish communities
need to examine relationship of race when they are the dominant group

Using tools of the oppressor when you
can't always rely on them is
rational + need to make a choice
WRT how Jews stand towards
benefit JOC to do away with
with using these tools
that can't even
be relied on

I think
this is
part of why u
have ppl say that
Jews are even more
privileged than "normal"
Antisemitism,
political discourse
race - Antisemitism
gets lost.

Chavottes will march - Sung goes to call police
but police didn't come, shocking - Black churches
did not even bother calling police - really interesting fact
LV Armed guards in front of Sung govt, assessing
"threats" - Agree w/ this! Reactions to threats show willingness to use tools
Responses to being threatened embedded in privilege whereas
to what extent is it helpful to view antisemitism racially?
Antisemitism often conceptualized by modern observers
as thru conspiracy theory
Historians will view history of antisemitism w/ anxiety
But race + racialization also has a role
Conceptualization of Jews as racially inclined
to commit arson fraud - used to perpetuate insurance
plans - at the time, Jews presumed to be responsible
for arson - hence Jewish defendant + racialized
LV If u comply w/ racial stereotypes then u must be
guilty of a crime

Feel like
this is
relevant given
current
stereotypes
of "leftists"

American not helping Jews in Holocaust + denying
application to flee - assumption that Jewish children would
grow up to be political radicals
Jews not being racialized as black but as Jews
Jews lazy but too industrious, crafty, will steal your
job, so we can't help refugees
People begging representatives to not grant Jews
refugee status
Great replacement theory as racialized conceptualization

Isn't the GAT that Jews are the ones
facilitating the replacement?

of Jews

Antisemitism intertwined w/ philo-Semitism - Jewish intelligence as bad

Race is least appreciated motivation of antisemitism

Q+A

How is racialization conceptualized?

↳ Have time pinning down what race is and the context

↳ Nothing to define at side of process of racialization

Focus on bodily races metaphysical race - the souls - of racialized people

Where are people willing to articulate differences of power

Race as a process and not actual content

Different meanings of race that exist at the same time